

FROG STORY

Written by

Alex Zhang

INT. APARTMENT - MORNING, RAINING

SHOT OF A PACKAGE OF "SPICY BBQ FLAVOUR HIGH PROTEIN CRICKETS" ON A KITCHEN TABLE. PAN TO THE TORSO AND LOWER BODY OF A MAN IN CASUAL INCONSPICUOUS ATTIRE WALKING BY INTO THE WASHROOM. HE DUNKS HIS HEAD INTO A FULL SINK. PAN UP AT THE MIRROR AS HE RISES TO REVEAL HE HAS THE HEAD OF A FROG.

He closes his eyes, takes a deep breath in, and lightly slaps his own face a few times, readying himself. His head suddenly shifts into that of a man in his mid-20s with large, almost bulging eyes and a long mouth. He fixes his hair and walks to the front door, his long tongue shooting out to grab a cricket as he leaves.

INT. CAFÉ/DINER - DAY, CLOUDY

It's busy and hectic today, with inaudible, loud chatter. The camera follows FROGHEAD, dressed in an apron, rushing around.

CLOSEUP OF FROGHEAD'S FACE AS HE ZIPS TO AND FRO, EYES WIDE AND AS IF THEY'LL POP RIGHT OUT, HIS SKIN TURNING EVER SO SLIGHTLY GREEN, WITH SOME MUCUS-LIKE SWEAT ACCUMULATING.

THE BOSS

(To FROGHEAD) "Hey, come on,
GILBERT! Chop chop!"

The boss is a bear of a man: tall and chubby with a thick brown beard and plentiful brown hair on his arms, dressed in a white shirt and a blue apron like the dude from "The Bear".

GILBERT

(His voice has a croaky quality that he tries to stifle, but he ends up sounding like a chainsmoking Kermit the Frog)
On it, BOSS! (He turns around) Hi, is there anything I could get you started with to drink?

PAN AROUND GILBERT TO REVEAL...

A COOL WOMAN wearing sunglasses sitting at the table, coolly staring off into the distance. She has white hair with pink streaks and a square face with a sharp jaw.

COOL WOMAN

(She speaks slowly and smoothly)
Hi, yeah. I'd like some OJ. With pulp if you have it...

GILBERT
(He is enamored)...Uh, yeah. Coming
right up!

CUT TO BACK OF HOUSE.

As GILBERT continues working, he glances at the COOL WOMAN. Quickly cut continuously between his infatuated face and her dreamy slight smile as she turns towards him. He averts his gaze, smiling at the ground.

GILBERT
(Excited, subtly hopping up and
down) *Eye tag!*

He cautiously peeks back. She's still gazing at him! Staring even! He quickly turns away, stifling his smile to look cool. He does this a few more times, looking like an idiot.

CUT TO GILBERT GRABBING JUICE AND PIE FROM THE KITCHEN WINDOW. RISING SHOT FROM BEHIND STARTING FROM HIS FEET SHOWING HIM ALMOST BOUNCING WITH EVERY STEP, PUFFING HIS CHEST AS THE FRAME REACHES HIS TORSO, AND AS HIS HEAD COMES INTO THE SHOT...THE COOL WOMAN GRABS A CANE AND SWINGS IT BACK AND FORTH AS SHE WALKS TO THE WASHROOM. CLOSEUP SHOT OF GILBERT'S EXASPERATION.

GILBERT
(Ribbit) *Idiot! She's blind!*

FAST PAN TO A MISCHIEF OF FIVE BACK-OF-HOUSE COWORKERS, WHO ARE GRINNING STUPIDLY AT HIM WITH CHEESY THUMBS UP. PAN BACK TO GILBERT.

He sighs and places the dishes on her table, but as he tries to remove his hands, his finger pads are stuck on.

GILBERT
Not now!!

JUMP CUTS OF ATTEMPTS TO PULL HIS SLIGHTLY WEBBED HANDS OFF OF THE DISHES WITH ALL OF HIS STRENGTH.

He hasn't found any success by the time COOL WOMAN emerges from the washroom. As she approaches the table, GILBERT hops over her cane as she sweeps it back and forth, perilously balancing the dishes in his hands. He is trying hard to preserve his chance at suavely presenting her food to her.

PAN Laterally Wildly in an Infrared Filter

GILBERT's amphibian vision is anxiously checking if people are noticing him acting really weird. Or even worse: finding out about his secret.

THE BOSS observes from behind the counter, which obscures GILBERT's lower body from view. From this angle, he is seemingly just very quirkily avoiding getting in her way.

THE BOSS
(Quietly) ...What the heck?

CLOSEUP ON GILBERT.

Stressed, he closes his eyes, takes a deep breath in, and calms himself.

ZOOM OUT AS HIS SKIN RETURNS TO HUMAN SHADE AND HIS FINGERS RELEASE FROM THE DISHES. CUT TO A SIDE SHOT OF THE TABLE.

GILBERT
Orange juice and one apple pie, on the house!

COOL WOMAN
Oh wow, thank you! I love apple pie, how did you know?"

GILBERT
(Laughs, less nervous) Lucky guess. My gut told me. Are you a regular? Maybe you've ordered before and my gut remembers.

His gut did not tell him anything: everyone likes apple pie.

COOL WOMAN
(She whistles her "s" sounds, creating sharp hisses in between her otherwise deeply smooth, resonant speech) No, I'm new in town. I actually came here because it looks like somewhere I could be a regular.

GILBERT
Oh, wow. I've lived here all my life so I could give you local recommendations if you'd like. I'm GILBERT, by the way.

COOL WOMAN
SALLY. I was actually just thinking about where I could find a--

CUT TO BACK OF HOUSE.

The coworkers are all watching intently, squeakily chattering and excitedly celebrating GILBERT's good moves.

One grabs a customer's bowl of cheesy fries from the service counter and tosses them in his mouth like popcorn. Two others get so hyper that they scurry and scamper around each other in a little circle. None of them notice THE BOSS standing angrily behind them, brandishing a spatula to punish them for mousing around during peak hours.

CUT TO A SIDE SHOT OF THE CONVERSATION FROM THE OPPOSITE SIDE OF THE TABLE.

The sun is now shining through the window, illuminating the place with a natural glow. A Wilhelm scream can be heard from the kitchen.

SALLY

--and everyone told me I should just play it safe, but I decided to follow my heart and come to the city to become a musician.

GILBERT

Must have been difficult..

He glances back to see THE BOSS is almost through with the coworkers. He needs to make his move soon or else THE BOSS will notice him slacking off! He spins his head back around to find his reflection in the window. Linger on the shot as his reflection's frog-like features emphasize.

GILBERT

Would-would, uh...

He's now looking at the ground rather than SALLY's eyes.

GILBERT

...Would you like to order anything else?

EXT. STREET - AFTERNOON, CLOUDY

TRACK GILBERT FROM THE SIDE AS HE WALKS, DISCOURAGED.

He passes by a vape store and shakes his head. He's annoyed with everything he sees.

GILBERT

People smoking away their gills...

He passes by an insect exterminator's office.

GILBERT

(Sucks his teeth) So much good food, gone to waste. Tsk...

He passes by a fertility centre with a poster of a white tadpole. It says "Strong babies start here!"

GILBERT

Amen. Such representation for the frog community. Why's the tadpole white though?

He passes by a restaurant named "Fryday", written in a bombastic neon green sign. The building facade is covered in promotional posters. The biggest and most noticeable read "Anything fried you can think of sold here!", "As fresh as can be!", and "Amazing fried chicken!".

GILBERT

Good riddance. Darn birds always eating us.

He double takes on a poster that says "We're hiring! Hoppingly energetic, experienced back-of-house workers wanted! \$More-than-the-café-pays-you.99 an hour!" As he stares at the poster, seriously considering it...

OMINOUSLY PAN TO A POSTER OVERLOOKED BY GILBERT. IT READS...

"Freshly croaked fried frog legs coming soon for Fall!!"

INT. APARTMENT - TIME UNCLEAR, UNLIT

SHOT OF A PHONE ON A TABLE WITH A CALL FROM "MOTHER." RINGING. PAN TO SALLY WALKING BY INTO THE WASHROOM.

She dunks her head into a full sink without a mirror.

DOLLY AROUND THE APARTMENT AS A VOICEMAIL PLAYS TO REVEAL MOVING BOXES FULL OF BRIGHTLY COLOURED BELONGINGS, VIOLINS, AND RECORDING EQUIPMENT IN A NEW AND STERILELY EMPTY APARTMENT WITH THE LIGHTS OFF.

SALLY'S MOTHER (VOICEMAIL)

BEEEP. (Apprehensively, tense, treading lightly. Like her daughter, she whistles her "s" sounds) Hey, SALLY. Just, uh, checking in...I know especially for you, moving can be really hard. Um, but you're a strong girl...

On the table sits many sunglasses and a tin of escargot.

SALLY'S MOTHER (VOICEMAIL)
How're ya doing with the job? I-I
know it can be fickle and--y-you
really should have taken that gig
back home, SAL! Jeez, a blind girl
taking all that risk, dreaming of--

She cuts herself off as she starts to get heated.

CUT TO A CLOSEUP OF SALLY AS SHE DOES HER MAKEUP.

Her expressions stay stoic as her mother speaks, with winces
of grief peaking through.

SALLY'S MOTHER (VOICEMAIL)
Sorry, I...shouldn't have gotten
mad atcha, last time we talked, at
what makes ya special: that you're
strong. And strongly stubborn.
But...you needa stop pushing people
away. Everybody needs support. I'm
here. Always. So just give me a
call, bubbles. And remember, always
keep your cane witcha.

SALLY picks up her phone and stares at it for a second,
motionless and about to call back. She decides against it,
instead walking towards the door, confidently without her
cane. However, she's not yet familiar with her new home and
stubs her toe super hard, losing her cool edgy aura.

SALLY
AH! OUCH! Oh, f--

EXT. FRYDAY - LATE AFTERNOON

A flock of Fryday employees, dressed the same as THE MANAGER,
are unloading ingredients from a delivery truck into the back
of the restaurant. Two of them laboriously lug a fish tank
out of the truck together.

ZOOM ON THE TANK TO REVEAL THAT IT IS STORING FROGS.

INT. FRYDAY MANAGER'S ROOM - LATE AFTERNOON

The room is clean, lifeless, and undecorated outside of a
collection of chicken bobbleheads on THE MANAGER's desk. He's
wearing a white polo with a red collar and has a very long
neck, a huge Adam's apple, and twitchy head movements.

CUT BETWEEN THE MANAGER AND GILBERT'S PERSPECTIVES, THE FRAME JUST WIDE ENOUGH TO INCLUDE THEIR TORSOS BUT JUST NARROW ENOUGH TO FEEL UNCOMFORTABLY CLOSE.

MANAGER

(He speaks corporately; soullessly joyful) Thanks for coming in today. So you are here for the Underwater Ceramic Technician role, is that right? Tell me, Wilbur, why us?

GILBERT

Yessir, um, my name is GILBERT, though. And I picked Fryday because... (looks down)

Cut to a shot of GILBERT's hand opening up to reveal marker writing that was smudged because of his sweaty palm.

GILBERT

(Looks back up, nervous) Um, I just...(ribbit)...am so passionate about all fried foods. And water. So washing dishes is my dream job!

MANAGER

Bless you. Um...great, Hilbert. We don't come by passionate dishwashers too often...So, tell me about your experience.

GILBERT

Yeah, so I have years of experience in the service industry. Most recently, I...

ZOOM ON AND TRACK A FLY BUZZING AROUND BEHIND THE MANAGER.

CLOSEUP ON GILBERT IN SLOW MOTION, HIS EYES DARTING BACK AND FORTH.

He licks his lips as he's captivated by eating the fly, but shakes his head to snap out of it, taking a deep breath before continuing waffling on.

INT. MUSIC CONSERVATORY - TIME UNCLEAR, DRAMATICALLY LIT

THE FRAME IS JUST WIDE ENOUGH TO INCLUDE SALLY'S TORSO BUT JUST NARROW ENOUGH TO FEEL UNCOMFORTABLY CLOSE

Sally is dressed in a concert black dress which, along with the unmoving black-and-brown backdrop of empty performers' chairs, contrasts with her colourful and lively hair.

She is vigorously playing the violin, as if taking her woe out on the instrument as she reaches the apex of a fast, tense piece. She concludes her piece with a loud, staccato, dramatic up-bow and holds her position, anticipatorily looking forward.

ACCELERATING JUMP CUTS IN SALLY'S PERSPECTIVE BETWEEN MANY JUDGES IN DIFFERENT ROOMS, SPlicing THEIR FEEDBACK TOGETHER AFTER SALLY'S MANY AUDITIONS.

JUDGE #1
...satisfactory, but you've said
that you only perform solo, yes?

JUDGE #2
...we're not looking for a one-
trick pony...

JUDGE #3
...one dimensional...

JUDGE #4
...one note...

JUDGE #1
...one...

CUT TO A WIDE SHOT OF SALLY WALKING THROUGH THE EMPTY CONSERVATORY CORRIDOR, DISCOURAGED.

The corridor's ceilings are high, vaulted, and intricate, giving the space a colossal feel that dwarfs SALLY and accentuates her isolated, discouraged walk. Uncontrollably upset, she strikes the wall beside her, unknowingly hitting a bulletin board made of soft cork with many postings.

SALLY
What the heck?

She puts her hand on the wall to check why her outlash did not hurt as much as she expected or wanted it to, running over an embossed braille paper. Its written version is posted right beside it, reading:

BAND LEADER (V.O.)
See how we wrote this in braille
too? We're super inclusive! Up-and-
coming destined-for-greatness band
looking for a violinist! Leave us a
fax at 5555512345!

CUT TO SIDE SHOT OF SALLY STARING AT THE POSTING, MOTIONLESS.

She lingers with her phone in her hand, faced with the same decision she made earlier and makes every day: do it alone, like she always has, or reach outward. Away from herself, away from everything she knows, toward chaos and vulnerability and the unseeable. After a long while, she makes a voice note:

SALLY
(Mumbling, reluctant) 5555512345...

INT. FRYDAY - EARLY EVENING, SUNNY

CUT TO A SHOT DOWN THE HALLWAY. DOLLY BACKWARDS AS THE TWO MEN WALK.

THE MANAGER, then GILBERT walk out of the door. As the manager looks forward, babbling all high-and-mighty about the restaurant's operations and success, GILBERT backpedals and shoots his tongue into the room, catching the fly at last. He darts his head to and fro, checking all directions with bulging-wide eyes to make sure no one saw as THE MANAGER continues, completely unaware if his interviewee is even listening to his corporate jargon speech.

THE MANAGER
...And, to piggyback further on that, our Q3 was even better last year, so I sent it up the flagpole to show that these were really scalable ways of moving the needle.

They arrive at the front-of-house and THE MANAGER gestures toward the other side of the room.

PAN TO SHOW THE FROG TANK INSTALLED HIGH UP ON THE WALL SO ALL CUSTOMERS CAN SEE JUST HOW FRYDAY KEEPS THEIR FOOD SO IMPECCABLY FRESH.

THE MANAGER
(Very proud of himself) Eh? How's that? Just installed. As a passionate lover of fried food, you must be droolin--Oh wow, way more passionate than I thought.

GILBERT has pressed his face and palms against the glass of the FROG TANK. The frogs, many very skinny and malnourished, look up at him with sad, beady eyes.

THE MANAGER
Hey, GILBERT? Would you please--

GILBERT promptly jumps backward.

GILBERT

Um, sorry, sir. I just...love fried food so much! (He forces a toothy, unconvincing smile) What, uh...will you be doing with them...?

THE MANAGER

We're frying them, of course! Frog legs are a delicacy in the Orient! We're tapping into a whole new customer base, and...

CLOSEUP ON GILBERT'S HORRIFIED, WIDE-FROWNING FACE AS THE MANAGER'S VOICE FADES OUT. HE TURNS TOWARD THE FROG TANK.

CUT TO GILBERT'S PERSPECTIVE AS HE STARES AT HIS REFLECTION IN THE FROG TANK, TRANSLUCENT BEFORE A TRAPPED FROG'S FACE.

He looks awfully human when contrasted with the poor guy.

LINGER ON THE SHOT AS HIS MEMORY PLAYS THROUGH A VOICEOVER:

GILBERT (V.O.)

Would-would, uh...would you like to order anything else?

He closes his eyes and takes a deep breath in, sharpening his resolve. His frog-like features accentuate. This time, he won't chicken out. He lunges toward the FROG TANK, embracing all of the frogs in his arms and removing them, turning tail to flee towards the front door, but THE MANAGER grabs on to him before he can get far. They begin wrestling for control.

THE MANAGER

What do you think you're doing, you weirdo?! Why are you actually passionate about this? Everyone lies in the interview! Hey, someone! Come help me get him!

GILBERT kicks THE MANAGER with the strength of a leaping frog. They each fly backward and fall over, GILBERT on the ground and THE MANAGER being caught by the flock of Fryday employees that have gathered around among the clamour. GILBERT's head has fully transformed into THE HEAD OF A FROG.

THE MANAGER

Hnghhh...that explains it! HE'S A DIRTY FROG! GET HIM!!

ZOOM OUT FROM THE MANAGER TO WATCH THE WHOLE FLOCK AS...

THE MANAGER, along with the other employees, transform into CHICKEN-HEADED MEN. They each reach deep behind their behinds into...perhaps very deep back pockets? Pops can be heard as they pull out eggs and barrage GILBERT with them. GILBERT dodges behind a knocked-over table and pants frantically before cracking a slight smile at the cute frogs in his arms.

THE FLOCK
BOK! BOK! BOK!

PAN AROUND WILDLY IN GILBERT'S PERSPECTIVE, ZOOMING IN ON A FIRE SPRINKLER AND THEN A FIRE EXTINGUISHER AND THEN THE CHICKEN-MEN CLOSING IN ON HIM.

GILBERT shoots his tongue at the sprinkler, triggering them to spray. He then pounces up, grabbing the fire extinguisher with his tongue, keeping the frogs in his arms comfy.

THE FLOCK
CLUCK! CLUCK! SCREEEEEEEECH!

The CHICKEN-MEN cower and shake their heads trying to dry off as their feathers get sopping wet. GILBERT stands triumphant in the rain, hydrated as ever.

GILBERT
(Cheesy impression of an action
hero, hardly intelligible since his
tongue is occupied)
Welcome to the swamp!!

He shoots THE FLOCK with the fire extinguisher, incapacitating them.

EXT. STREET - EARLY EVENING, SUNNY

GILBERT frolics with his freed frog babies, bouncing exceptionally high as he skips and wagging his long tongue around in joy, unapologetically froggy.

CUT TO OTHER DIRECTION, WESTWARD, AS SALLY WALKS INTO FRAME.

SALLY is postured as if she wants to shrink into herself. Unsure of herself and her future, she wants to be alone to cope with having been vulnerable with her art.

An unaware GILBERT crashes into SALLY. They both stay upright, but the frogs and SALLY's cane fall onto the ground.

GILBERT
SALLY! I'm sorry! Are you alright?

He instinctively reverts to human-headedness as he picks up SALLY's cane and some of the frogs.

SALLY

GILBERT? Oh, that's okay, happens often. (Receives the cane) Thank you. What did I make you drop? It sounds like I caused you more trouble.

GILBERT

Um, uh...

He tenses, scrambling to find a suitable lie as his habits compel him to hide the frogs. However, this time he relaxes, his natural bright green complexion returning. The sun begins to set in the background.

GILBERT

(Gleefully) They're my frogs! I just rescued them! Wanna hold them?

SALLY cracks a smile but quickly resists and goes back to looking conflicted and somber. Her habits tell her to go brood alone...but the absurdity makes her laugh.

SALLY

...Sure. So, where did you rescue them from? I can't believe this.

She laughs as the frogs affectionately hop into her arms.

GILBERT

You're never gonna believe this...

The two walk down the street as GILBERT laughs at SALLY's snarky comments on his FROG STORY and some of the frogs curiously guide SALLY forward, gathered around her feet.

INT. SALLY'S APARTMENT - EVENING, MOONLIT

SHOT OF SALLY'S PHONE ON HER TABLE DISPLAYING "MOTHER. CALL?"
ZOOM OUT TO A SIDE SHOT OF SALLY SEATED IN FRONT OF IT.

SALLY finds herself motionless in front of her phone, faced with a decision, again. She waits for her mind to make itself, this time only for a few seconds, and taps her phone.

As the phone rings, SALLY grabs a tin of escargot, opens it with her bare hands, and pours the contents into her mouth.

Chewing happily, the blind girl's head shifts into that of a SALAMANDER.